to secure jobs in the urban labour market and consolidated over the 20th century in particular sectors and firms. For instance, Saran's share of weavers in the Titaghur Jute Mill rose from a third in 1902 to three-fourths in 1991.[24] Female migration was not altogether absent but since the early 20th century, a combination of forces such as ideas of domesticity, male-dominated trade union politics and maternity benefit legislations led to the reduction of women's contribution to the jute industry of Kolkata.[25]

On the other hand, the women of Bihar were haunted by the women of Bengal amidst doubts that the *Bangaaliniya Sunnri*, or beautiful Bengali women, would seduce their husbands.[26] This theme is embedded in a rich culture of Bhojpuri folk songs on separated existence where the *purab* (the east) is portrayed as a dangerous site full of temptations. Celebrating the ideal loyal wife, Bhojpuri folk songs also lamented a life of exile, paradoxically for the woman of Bihar as she waited for her husband. The songs also talk of money and remittances and the gifts in store for those waiting and virtues of migration espoused by the migrants themselves. As noted by an official in the early 20th century, 'every coolie who emigrates, on his return becomes an apostle of it.'[27]

While Saran's migrant connection with Kolkata continued into the 21st century, it had also diversified its destinations like many other regions of Bihar. No longer was the male migrant only purab-bound. Kolkata's relative economic decline and the loss of agricultural fields to Bangladesh on account of Partition led migrants to seek new destinations west of Bihar. First, the fields of Punjab beckoned as the Green Revolution had led to a surge in demand for agricultural labour in the 1970s. Next, Delhi emerged as a powerful magnet for Bhojpuri-speaking migrant workers in the late 20th century for a variety of informal sector jobs. Economic dynamism in west India led to yet another option for migration. Finally, the Gulf countries have emerged as attractive destinations.

Unlike Ratnagiri and Udupi, Saran found itself among the poorest parts of India and the world in the 21st century. Mass migration had led to a widening of opportunities and a relatively secure source of income but could not dent poverty significantly at the regional level due to corrupt